

More fuel in a broken engine

By Jason Rigolli — Founder, Revved for Growth · <https://fixyourrevenueengine.com/insights/more-fuel-broken-engine/>

TL;DR. When pipeline stalls, most founders default to more spend or more headcount. Both make the problem worse if the engine itself is broken. The real fix is diagnostic before additive: figure out which stage of the revenue system is leaking, then redesign it. Adding fuel to a broken engine just buys more expensive stagnation.

Maya cut her marketing director six months ago. Pipeline didn't recover.

Today her head of sales sat across the table with a \$250K hire-plan deck, two SDRs and an enterprise AE, built on the assumption that cutting marketing freed up the budget for sales execution. The year-end number Maya promised her board in January is now \$1.8M out of reach. She's the one who's going to have to explain it.

If you've already cut marketing and your revenue is still stalled, the problem was never marketing. And the next hire, agency, or tool you're about to sign won't fix it either.

If you already cut marketing, you already half-agreed with me

A year ago, your marketing function wasn't producing. You looked at the numbers, made a defensible call, and reallocated. That call wasn't the problem.

What's on your desk now is the problem.

The SDR pod. The agency retainer your VP Sales has been quietly making the case for. The RevOps tool that promises to clean up the handoffs you already know are broken. Different line item. Same instinct. The instinct is: spend something to fix it.

More fuel in a broken engine just produces more expensive stagnation.

Most founders I sit down with at this stage have been here before. They cut a previous quarter's underperforming function, expected the rest of the engine to absorb the slack, and watched the stall continue under new packaging. The function changed. The output didn't. That's not a coincidence.

The fuel changed. The diagnosis didn't

The counter to all of this is real, and it's worth taking seriously.

A disciplined operator looks at an unproductive line item, kills it, and funds the productive one. Marketing wasn't producing; cut it. Sales is closing every qualified deal; fund it. That's capital allocation working as it's supposed to. By that reading, the \$250K hire plan isn't a misdiagnosis. It's exactly what the founder should be doing.

I think it's the same diagnosis applied to a different line item.

What gets missed in that reading: the assumption that sales is converting "every qualified deal" depends on what counts as qualified. The assumption that the marketing cut "freed up budget" depends on whether the demand that function used to produce is being made up somewhere else. The assumption that more SDR capacity will close the pipeline gap depends on whether the gap is a capacity problem or a conversion problem.

Most stalled \$5M-\$15M engines I've walked through fail one of those three assumptions. The hire plan funds the wrong constraint. Six months later, the founder is sitting across from a different head of sales, looking at a different deck, having the same conversation.

The test you can run before the next hire

Three things to look at before signing the deck.

One. The actual conversion rate from SQL to closed-won over the last four quarters. Not the lifetime number. The recent number. If it's flat or worse, and the pipeline-coverage ratio hasn't changed, then more SDRs are funding a constraint that isn't the one that's broken. The opportunities are arriving. They're not getting through.

Two. Whether two people on the existing commercial team can name the same three reasons deals are stalling in the last 30 days of the cycle. Not the high-level reasons. The specific operational ones. Pricing surprise in legal review. A second stakeholder appearing late. A use-case the deck doesn't address. If you ask three people and get three different lists, the qualification call isn't the call you think it is, and an extra AE inherits that problem on day one.

Three. What happens to existing pipeline if you do nothing for sixty days. If you don't sign the hire plan, don't sign the agency, don't buy the tool. Does the pipeline that's already in the system mature into bookings, or does it shrink? If it matures, the constraint sits upstream of the room you're about to add people to. If it shrinks, the question is deeper than "do I have enough sales capacity?"

None of these three need a paid diagnostic. They need ninety minutes, a quiet room, and a willingness to look at the engine instead of the spreadsheet. If the answers all point to a sales

capacity gap, sign the hire plan, the diagnosis was sound. If any of them don't, the \$250K should sit on the table until you've walked the engine end-to-end.

What changes

The fastest test of whether the engine is broken isn't the next hire. It's whether the people already in the room can answer "what's actually breaking in our last 30 days of every cycle?" the same way. Until they can, more fuel doesn't fix it.

Frequently asked

Why does adding sales or marketing spend often fail to fix stalled pipeline?

Because the bottleneck is rarely the top of the funnel. When conversion, hand-offs, or close rates are broken, more inputs just expose the failure faster. Spend amplifies whatever is already happening, including the leak.

How do you diagnose a broken revenue engine?

Map the system end to end: lead source quality, MQL-to-SQL conversion, sales cycle by stage, win rate by segment, expansion and churn. The leak almost always lives at a specific stage. Find it, fix it, then add fuel.

What's the difference between a fractional CRO and a marketing or sales agency?

An agency runs a function for you. A fractional CRO rebuilds the system that connects marketing, sales, and customer success. Agencies optimize their lane. A CRO owns the curve.

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Jason Rigolli fixes the reason a company isn't hitting its number. A two-time co-founder with three CRO seats and over two decades rebuilding revenue engines, he works inside founder-led, family-owned, and PE-backed B2B firms (\$2M-\$15M) across winning, keeping, and growing customers.

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